In 1971 Pakistan was going through a political crisis. In the elections to the national assembly, the Awami League, led by Sheikh Mujib-ur-Rehman, had won a majority by making a clean sweep in East Pakistan, winning 160 seats, whereas Zulfikar Ali Bhutto's Pakistan People's Party won about half that number. Taking a rational view, there appeared no option other than to make Sheikh Mujib the prime minister of Pakistan. As this did not happen, the internal situation in East Pakistan worsened. Eventually, the Bengali people of East Pakistan revolted and on 23 March 1971, independence was declared and Bangladeshi flags were unfurled all over. On the evening of 25 March, Sheikh Mujib declared the creation of the People's Republic of Bangladesh. In a broadcast, he stated, 'From today Bangladesh is independent. I call upon the people of Bangladesh to resist the army of occupation to the last….'

In an act of vengeance, the same night, the Pakistan Army unleashed Operation Search Light, a ruthless and repressive campaign to subdue the alienated population. Sheikh Mujib was arrested and whisked away to jail in West Pakistan. Hundreds were killed or arrested and many other atrocities like rape and pillage took place. Streams of Bengali refugees, both Muslims and Hindus, started pouring in from strife-torn East Pakistan, which was witnessing a civil war between the 'Mukti Bahini' freedom fighters and the Pakistan Army.

As a great diplomatic move, India signed a treaty of friendship with the Soviet Union on 9 August 1971. 'Andrei Gromyko, the Soviet foreign minister, visited New Delhi and signed this treaty. It was one of the best-kept secrets in Indo-Soviet relations.'[2] The most vital and crucially important aspects of the treaty were contained in Articles VIII to XI, 'which provided for an all-encompassing commitment of defence cooperation and mutual defence assistance in case of either party being subjected to threats to their territorial integrity and security,' wrote J.N. Dixit. This treaty reshaped the politics and geography of our region.

The intensity of the skirmishes between the 'Mukti Bahini' and the Pakistan Army along the Indo-East Pakistan border increased in the later part of 1971, leading to a conflict situation. Open hostilities in